

An illustration of several orchids with yellow and purple petals. Several small, metallic blue-green bees with transparent wings are flying around the flowers. One bee is shown landing on a yellow petal.

Orchids

Orchid bee

Scented bugs

Male orchid bees, or euglossine bees, collect special oils from the orchids they visit and wear them as perfume. This is thought to help them attract mates.

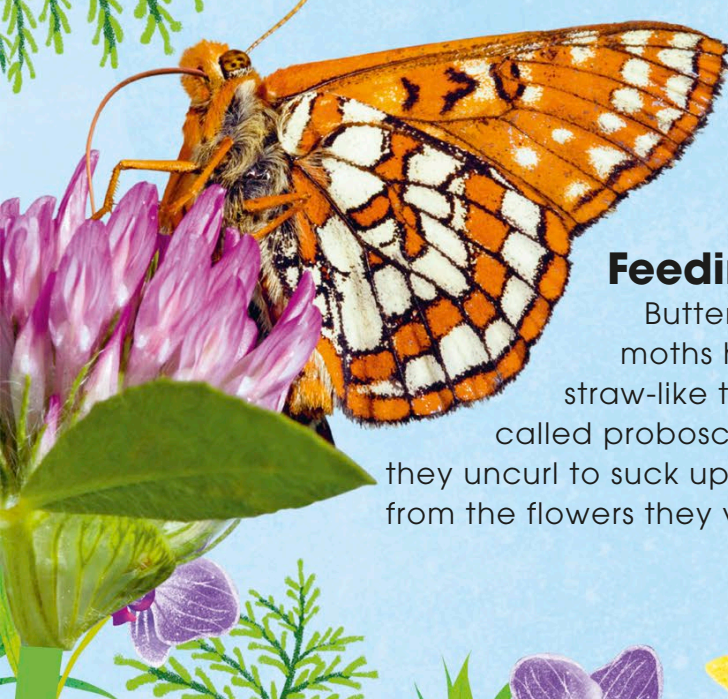
Bees are important pollinators.

Pollinators

Flowers make a huge effort to attract insects, because insects help pollinate them. They use bright colors and strong smells to show off their nectar, a sugary liquid that many insects like to eat. When an insect lands on a flower to feed, it is dusted in powdery pollen. This pollen is then carried to new flowers, allowing them to produce seeds.

A detailed illustration of a bumblebee with black and yellow stripes, hovering near a green leaf.

Bumblebee

A large illustration of an Anicia checkerspot butterfly with orange and white checkered wings, perched on a pink flower.

Anicia
checkerspot
butterfly

Feeding time

Butterflies and moths have long, straw-like tongues, called proboscises, which they uncurl to suck up nectar from the flowers they visit.

An illustration of a hummingbird hawk-moth with long wings and a long proboscis, feeding from a yellow flower. The proboscis is shown uncurled and inserted into the flower's center.

Hummingbird
hawk-moth

Proboscis